STIVEN CATALYST

SECOND SERIES · OCTOBER 2026

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



PEOPLE

MOTIVATION: AUTONOMY, COMPETENCE, RELATEDNESS

Three needs behind motivation, what 99 studies show each one carries, the line from “have to” to “want to”, what pay buys, how support for autonomy is learned and a card for one role.

42% of the variance in intrinsic motivation at work was explained by the three needs together, in a review of 99 studies.

VAN DEN BROECK ET AL., 2016

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NO. 60 · PEOPLE

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Most talk about motivation asks how much of it people have. Self-determination theory asks what kind: whether people work because they want to, because they see the point, or because they feel pushed. Three needs lie behind that difference, and a manager can do something about each.

Richard Ryan and Edward Deci named three needs: autonomy, competence and relatedness. In 99 studies, autonomy carried most of what the needs explain in engagement, competence most of it in task performance. A manager's support for autonomy goes with wanting and valuing the work, and not with pressure. Over 40 years of research, intrinsic motivation predicted the quality of work, incentives its quantity. And the style can be learned: in one study, within five weeks.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editor interprets rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Three needs, not one carrot

In 2000 Richard Ryan and Edward Deci summed up their research: people can be curious and engaged, or like the many who “wait listlessly for the weekend as they go about their jobs”. The difference, they argued, lies in three needs.

01
Autonomy
acting with a sense of choice and ownership, not pushed and pulled from outside

02
Competence
feeling able to master the work and to grow new skills

03
Relatedness
feeling connected to others: belonging, caring and being cared for

Autonomy is the most misunderstood of the three, because it does not mean independence. Anja Van den Broeck and colleagues give an example: a manager asks someone to finish a task over lunch. If the person agrees willingly, the need is met; if they feel forced, it is thwarted. The task stays the same.

OUR READING

Autonomy is not the absence of a manager. It is the difference between “I agreed” and “I had no choice”.

Sources: Richard M. Ryan & Edward L. Deci, American Psychologist 55(1), 2000; Anja Van den Broeck, D. Lance Ferris, Chu-Hsiang Chang & Christopher C. Rosen, Journal of Management 42(5), 2016

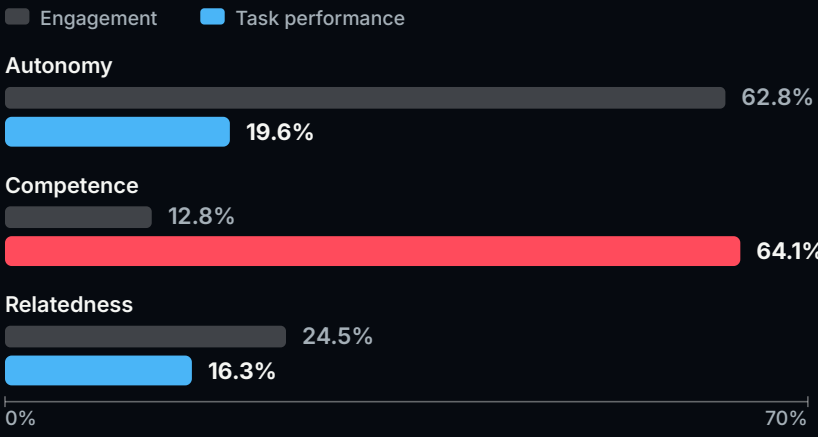
The definitions follow Ryan & Deci (2000) and Van den Broeck et al. (2016), whose lunch example this is. The quotation is from the American Psychologist; the translation is ours.

THE NUMBERS

Which need carries what

Anja Van den Broeck and colleagues pooled 99 studies with 119 samples of adults at work. Each need predicted outcomes on its own, though not equally. This is how the three divided what they explain:

SHARE OF WHAT THE THREE NEEDS EXPLAIN, BY NEED



Together the needs explained 43% of the variance in engagement and 17% in task performance. Of the three, autonomy was most closely related to job satisfaction (ρ = 0.69), competence to task performance (0.40).

OUR READING

Choice keeps people engaged; feeling able shows in the work itself. A team needs both, and a manager feeds each in a different way.

Source: Anja Van den Broeck, D. Lance Ferris, Chu-Hsiang Chang & Christopher C. Rosen, Journal of Management 42(5), 2016

Relative weights from the authors' Table 7; ρ is a correlation corrected for measurement error. The studies measure needs and outcomes side by side, so they show association, not cause.

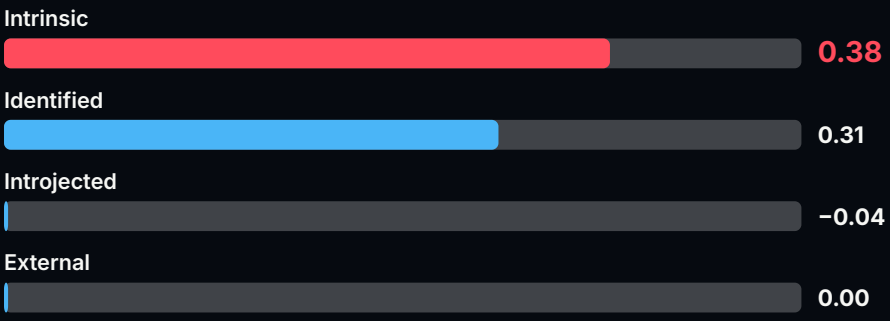
THE MODEL

From “have to” to “want to”

Rather than setting intrinsic against extrinsic motivation, the theory places the reasons for working on a line, from none at all to the work itself. Along that line, a rule can be taken in until it becomes one's own.

01	02	03	04	05
No motivation	**External**	**Introjected**	**Identified**	**Intrinsic**
going through the motions	for a reward, or to avoid a punishment	to avoid guilt, or to feel worth something	because I see its value	because the work itself satisfies

MANAGER'S SUPPORT FOR AUTONOMY, CORRELATION WITH EACH REASON (12–22 STUDIES)



OUR READING

With the next new rule, say why it exists. The reason behind a rule is what moves it from “have to” towards “want to”.

Sources: Richard M. Ryan & Edward L. Deci, American Psychologist 55(1), 2000; Gavin R. Slemp, Margaret L. Kern, Kent J. Patrick & Richard M. Ryan, Motivation and Emotion 42(5), 2018

The line follows Ryan & Deci (2000), who also place integrated regulation before intrinsic motivation. Slemp et al. pooled 32,870 people; ρ is corrected for measurement error, and most of the studies are cross-sectional.

More in the essay Leading people without losing the person

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Pay buys quantity

Christopher Cerasoli, Jessica Nicklin and Michael Ford pooled 40 years of research from school, work and sport. Intrinsic motivation predicted performance moderately to strongly, whether or not incentives were offered.

212,468
people, in 183 effect sizes

ρ = 0.21–0.45
between intrinsic motivation and performance

Weighed together, intrinsic motivation explained more of the quality of performance, incentives more of its quantity. Where incentives were tied directly to performance, intrinsic motivation counted for less. In a study of 166 bank employees in Norway, the amount of pay did not predict need satisfaction or intrinsic motivation; the manager's support for employees' needs did.

OUR READING

A bonus can count pieces. Quality shows care for the work, and a bonus on every piece can crowd that care out.

Sources: Christopher P. Cerasoli, Jessica M. Nicklin & Michael T. Ford, Psychological Bulletin 140(4), 2014 (via Abstract (PubMed) and Deci, Olafsen & Ryan (2017)); Anja H. Olafsen, Hallgeir Halvari, Jacques Forest & Edward L. Deci, Scandinavian Journal of Psychology 56(4), 2015 (via Abstract and Deci, Olafsen & Ryan (2017)); Edward L. Deci, Anja H. Olafsen & Richard M. Ryan, Annual Review of Organizational Psychology and Organizational Behavior 4, 2017

Cerasoli et al. as given in the abstract and in the summary by Deci, Olafsen & Ryan (2017); we could not obtain the full article. The bank study is a single survey (Olafsen et al., 2015).

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Ask why, not how much

The Multidimensional Work Motivation Scale was tested with 3,435 workers in seven languages and nine countries. Instead of asking how motivated someone is, its 19 items ask for the reasons behind their effort at work, from none at all to the work itself.

What employees are asked about their manager (Deci et al., 2017)

1. acknowledges my point of view
2. offers choices and encourages initiative
3. gives meaningful feedback and optimally challenging tasks
4. gives a reason when asking for something

The style can be learned. In a study published in 1989, Deci and colleagues trained the managers of one division of a large company; their employees later reported more job satisfaction and more trust in top management. Patricia Hardré and Johnmarshall Reeve trained 25 managers with 169 employees. Five weeks later the trained managers were more autonomy supportive, and their employees more autonomously motivated and engaged than a control group's.

Sources: Marylène Gagné, Jacques Forest, Maarten Vansteenkiste et al., European Journal of Work and Organizational Psychology 24(2), 2015; Edward L. Deci, Anja H. Olafsen & Richard M. Ryan, Annual Review of Organizational Psychology and Organizational Behavior 4, 2017; Patricia L. Hardré & Johnmarshall Reeve, International Journal of Training and Development 13(3), 2009 (via Abstract and Deci, Olafsen & Ryan (2017)); Gavin R. Slemp, Margaret L. Kern, Kent J. Patrick & Richard M. Ryan, Motivation and Emotion 42(5), 2018

The scale is copyrighted, so we name what it measures rather than its items. The four lines summarise the behaviours listed by Deci et al. Slemp et al. (2018) note that both training studies had small samples.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The three-needs card

Take one role in your team rather than one person. For each need, write what the job gives today and one change you can make this month. Then ask the people in the role whether you got it right.

01 Role which role, how many people, the main task

02 Autonomy where they can choose how; one rule to explain with its reason

03 Competence how they see they do it well; one stretch task or piece of feedback

04 Relatedness who they depend on and who notices their work; one moment together

05 Changes one per need, with an owner and a date

06 Asked back what the people in the role said, in their words

Sources: Richard M. Ryan & Edward L. Deci, American Psychologist 55(1), 2000; Edward L. Deci, Anja H. Olafsen & Richard M. Ryan, Annual Review of Organizational Psychology and Organizational Behavior 4, 2017

A suggestion from the editors, drawing on the three needs of Ryan & Deci (2000) and the managerial behaviours listed by Deci, Olafsen & Ryan (2017). The card is not a measurement scale.

Open the tool: KPI Diagnostic stivencatalyst.com/tools/kpi-diagnostic/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Self-Determination Theory and the Facilitation of Intrinsic Motivation, Social Development, and Well-Being
Richard M. Ryan & Edward L. Deci, American Psychologist 55(1), 2000
https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

A Review of Self-Determination Theory's Basic Psychological Needs at Work
Anja Van den Broeck, D. Lance Ferris, Chu-Hsiang Chang & Christopher C. Rosen, Journal of Management 42(5), 2016
https://doi.org/10.1177/0149206316632058

Leader autonomy support in the workplace: A meta-analytic review
Gavin R. Slemp, Margaret L. Kern, Kent J. Patrick & Richard M. Ryan, Motivation and Emotion 42(5), 2018
https://doi.org/10.1007/s11031-018-9698-y

Intrinsic motivation and extrinsic incentives jointly predict performance: A 40-year meta-analysis
Christopher P. Cerasoli, Jessica M. Nicklin & Michael T. Ford, Psychological Bulletin 140(4), 2014 · via Abstract (PubMed) and Deci, Olafsen & Ryan (2017)
https://doi.org/10.1037/a0035661

Show them the money? The role of pay, managerial need support, and justice in a self-determination theory model of intrinsic work motivation
Anja H. Olafsen, Hallgeir Halvari, Jacques Forest & Edward L. Deci, Scandinavian Journal of Psychology 56(4), 2015 · via Abstract and Deci, Olafsen & Ryan (2017)
https://doi.org/10.1111/sjop.12211

Self-Determination Theory in Work Organizations: The State of a Science
Edward L. Deci, Anja H. Olafsen & Richard M. Ryan, Annual Review of Organizational Psychology and Organizational Behavior 4, 2017
https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-orgpsych-032516-113108

The Multidimensional Work Motivation Scale: Validation evidence in seven languages and nine countries
Marylène Gagné, Jacques Forest, Maarten Vansteenkiste et al., European Journal of Work and Organizational Psychology 24(2), 2015
https://doi.org/10.1080/1359432X.2013.877892

Training corporate managers to adopt a more autonomy-supportive motivating style toward employees: an intervention study
Patricia L. Hardré & Johnmarshall Reeve, International Journal of Training and Development 13(3), 2009 · via Abstract and Deci, Olafsen & Ryan (2017)
https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-2419.2009.00325.x

CORRECTION · 12 OCTOBER 2026

The chart of the manager's support for autonomy now gives its base as 12 to 22 studies, the number behind each correlation; it first said 72, the studies of the whole meta-analysis.

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what it measures, in the full text where it could be opened. A source read only in a summary, an abstract or excerpts is marked “via”. A figure not confirmed in what was read is marked so on its page, or left out. The editor's interpretation is marked “Our reading”.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html